distinct parts: the massive chain of mountains to the north—2,500 kilometres in length and 250 to 300 kilometres in width—that acts as a formidable barrier against the Tibetan Plateau; the Indo-Gangetic plain that extends from the Indus in Pakistan in the west to the Brahmaputra in the east; the Central Indian Plateau; and finally the Deccan Plateau flanked on either side by the Eastern and Western Ghats and the coastal regions.

The most striking geographic feature is undoubtedly the Himalayan chain that has over 114 peaks that touch heights of over 20,000 feet. The northwestern corner of this forbidding wall is made of sheer rock and ice, a part of the Hindu Kush mountains that adjoin the Karakoram range. Further in, running parallel to the Karakoram are the Ladakh, Zanskar and Great Himalayan ranges, each with their own valleys and plateaus that have formed separate kingdoms in the past. Together this great wall then runs eastwards through Lahaul-Spiti, Kinnaur, Garhwal, Kumaon, Nepal, then on to Sikkim, Bhutan and what was then NEFA (Arunachal Pradesh).

Linked to the Himalayas but running north to south, the Kirthar, Sulaiman and Safed Koh ranges form a massive defensive barrier in the west. In the east the Naga Patkai ranges similarly branch off to the south becoming the Naga Hills and the Manipur Plateau before further linking up with the Chin and Lushai Hills and then the Arakan Yoma before tapering off at Cape Negris in the Bay of Bengal. Collectively, these mountains literally take the shape of a helmet adorning the head of the subcontinent, making ingress into the region rather difficult.

Difficult does not mean impossible, however, especially in the face of a determined invader. Despite their ruggedness and forbidding look, the Western Himalayas have always proved to be rather porous. A succession of invaders, from ancient to medieval times, made their way across passes in the Hindu Kush and the southern ranges that formed the western boundary. Once across the few known and rarely guarded passes, invading armies could follow the linking river valleys into the subcontinent. The most favoured route was along the Kabul Valley into the northern part of the Indus Plain, or through Central Afghanistan through the Kurram, Tochi or Gomal valleys directly into West Punjab (now in Pakistan).

Though the bulk of the landmass then stretches southwards from the mountain wall, life in the upper half of the subcontinent has largely been defined by the Himalayas. The Great Plains are formed by the thick alluvial